

Understanding Dreams

*Lecture 1 — What Dreams Are, Where They Come From,
and What They Have Meant to Humanity*

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Tonight's homework: Write down one of your dreams, bring it to Lecture 2, and if you're willing send me a copy (randycharlton@gmail.com) and I will include two or three in Wednesday's lecture.

Dement's Sleep and Dreams — Stanford University

The Question at the Heart of our Two Lectures

Do dreams mean anything?

- What is actually happening when we dream?
- What have human beings across history believed dreams are for?
- What do Freud, Jung, and modern neuroscientists say — and where do they disagree?
- Can you learn something real and useful about yourself from your own dreams?

Lecture 1 — Roadmap



A dream of mine — before any theory



You are not alone: dreams across cultures/common dreams



What is a dream? Observational neuroscience, simply



What humans have said about dreams: ancient to modern



Why dreams matter — a clinical encounter



Freud: dreams as disguised wishes



Jung: dreams as developmental messages



How to work with your own dreams



Homework: your dream diary

Dr. Charlton's Dream — “Lost”

I leave Frost Amphitheater to go home after a performance. I was with my friend Marty, but I lost him in the crowd.

I am alone, walking along a path behind the apartments and shops on El Camino. I think my car is parked in this direction, but I'm not sure.

I walk on and it gets dark. The path is now bordered by 30 foot high cement walls that I think shouldn't be there. I begin to doubt I'll find the car or ever see Marty again.

Before We Analyze Anything —

What do you notice?

- Close your eyes. Imagine you're in the dream, really there!, walking in the dark to find your car and go home. You reach the cement walls. You're utterly alone. What do you feel?
- What do you think or imagine the dreamer is feeling about his life? About himself?
- What is the most vivid image in the dream? What does it bring into your mind?
- Does anything in this dream remind you of a feeling or a dream you've had?

Hold your thoughts. We'll return to this dream at the end of the lecture.

You Are Not Alone

Dreams across cultures · What nearly everyone dreams about · Why this matters

Dreams Across Cultures — What Nearly Everyone Dreams About

*Two independent studies from radically different cultures. Notice the commonality.
The numbers indicate % of positive responders.*

Chinese Students (Yu, 2008)	Canadian Students (Nielsen, 2003)
Being chased or pursued 92%	Being chased or pursued 82%
Falling 87%	Sexual experiences 77%
Arriving too late 81%	Falling 74%
Failing an examination 79%	Schools, teachers, studying 67%
Trying again and again and failing 74%	Arriving too late 60%
Flying or soaring 74%	Trying again and again and failing 54%
Being frozen with fright 71%	Flying or soaring 48%
Sexual experiences 70%	Vividly sensing an unseen presence in the room 48%

Raise your hand if you have had any of these dreams

Common Dreams — What They Tend to Mean

Certain dream themes are so universal that their broad meaning is reasonably well understood — though the specific meaning is always personal:

Anxiety Dreams

A previously successful experience is presented as failure in the dream. The exam you haven't studied for, the performance you're unprepared for. Often connected to current performance fears not visible in the dream — common across all cultures.

Chase Dreams

Being pursued by a threatening figure you cannot see or cannot outrun. Often reflects something in waking life that the dreamer is avoiding or not yet ready to confront.

Flying Dreams

More common in younger people, often pleasurable. Associated with freedom from limitation, escape from constraint, and sometimes with early experiences of omnipotence or play.

Falling Dreams

Often connected to a sudden loss of control or support. May be related to transitions, anxiety about failure, or a developmental shift that feels destabilizing.

The Familiar Stranger

A figure in the dream who seems known, but whom you cannot identify upon waking. Often represents a disowned aspect of yourself — what Jung called the Shadow.

The Unknown Room

Discovering a room in a known house that you never realized was there. Can represent an undiscovered aspect of the self - a new developmental possibility, could be positive or negative to the conscious mind

What Is a Dream?

Some of what happens in the body & brain while we sleep

What Is a Dream? — A Working Definition

A dream is a unique form of experience that the sleeping mind generates entirely from within itself. Unlike waking perception, nothing outside you is immediately creating what you see, feel, and believe in a dream.

Internally Generated

No external sensory input. The visual, emotional, and narrative world of the dream is created entirely by the dreaming brain.

Emotionally Real

The fear in a nightmare is real fear. The joy in a flying dream is real joy. The emotion of a dream is not simulated — it is produced by the same systems that generate waking emotion.

Accepted Without Question

In a dream you rarely realize you are dreaming. The brain suspends the disbelief mechanism. A dream is its own reality.

Owned as Mine

Upon waking, the dream is yours — “I had a dream.” Not “A dream happened to me.” The dreaming mind is your mind, however strange its productions.

Voluntarily Uncontrollable (yes, lucid dreaming is a thing)

Muscular control is limited in normal dreaming. You cannot direct the content/feeling of a dream the way you can direct a daydream. The dream goes where it goes. This involuntary quality is what makes it such an interesting clinical object.

Primarily Visual but Multisensory

Dreams are predominantly visual, but they incorporate emotion, bodily sensation, movement, and sometimes sound. Touch and smell are rarer, but possible.

What Humans Have Said About Dreams

From ancient Mesopotamia to Cinderella · A brief history of dream interpretation

The Ancient World — Dreams as Divine Messages

For most of human history, in nearly every culture, dreams were understood as communications from gods, spirits, or the dead.

Mesopotamia ~3000 BCE

The earliest recorded dream interpretations come from ancient Sumer. Dreams were sent by the gods. Priests and priestesses served as professional dream interpreters. The Epic of Gilgamesh is built around prophetic dreams.

Ancient Egypt ~1300 BCE

The Chester Beatty Papyrus is one of the world's first dream dictionaries. Egyptians slept in temples to receive healing dreams from the god Serapis. Dreams were believed to reveal the will of the gods.

Herodotus 440 BCE

"The visions that occur to us in dreams are, more often than not, the things we have been concerned about during the day." — Already noticing the day residue, 2,400 years before Freud named it.

Zhuang Zhou 369 BCE

"One dreams at night what one thinks about during the day." — And yet he also famously dreamed he was a butterfly, and wondered on waking: am I a man who dreamed of being a butterfly, or a butterfly now dreaming I am a man?

The Talmud

"A dream which is not interpreted is like a letter which is not read." — Dreams carry information. Ignoring a dream is to refuse a communication.

Aristotle 350 BCE

The first to suggest that dreams might have a natural rather than divine cause — observing that even animals seem to dream, which suggests it is unlikely that dreams were divine messages intended for humans.

Modern Voices on Dreams — From Literature to Science

Dreams have fascinated artists, writers, and scientists in ways that reveal what each era values most about inner life.

Erich Fromm

“A dream is a microscope through which we look at the hidden occurrences in our soul.”

Carl Jung

“Dreams may contain ineluctable truths, philosophical pronouncements, illusions, wild fantasies, memories, plans, anticipations, irrational experiences, even telepathic visions — and heaven knows what besides.”

Sigmund Freud

“Dreams are the royal road to a knowledge of the unconscious activities of the mind.”

William Dement, MD

“Dreaming permits each and every one of us to be quietly and safely insane every night of our lives.”

M. C. Escher

“I don’t use drugs; my dreams are frightening enough.”

Cinderella (1950)

“A dream is a wish your heart makes.” — Mack David (songwriters sometimes get there first.)

Why Dreams Matter

A clinical encounter · What dreams can reveal that waking life cannot

The Dream of a 72-year-old retired veterinarian - he couldn't title it, but he'd never forget it

I am in a dark space and I know my wife is next to me. From the darkness someone I cannot see reaches out and grabs her. He takes her away. I understand somehow that he is going to hurt her.

The Morning After the Dream

What the patient told me: *“I told my wife the dream the next day. I was honest until I got to the end. Then I said that someone took her away — to summer camp. You know, I didn’t want her to think that someone could hurt her.”*

Why Dreams Matter — What This Moment Reveals

The dream knew something the patient couldn’t face:

A man who could not consciously acknowledge that he dreamt of her abduction and harm — could not think it, feel it, say it — dreamed it. The unconscious spoke what waking life censored.

The lie is the clinical material:

He didn’t just dream something revealing. He hid it from his wife and perhaps himself. The lie revealed thoughts and feelings he had never been able to approach: Who is the unseen kidnapper? Why did he change the ending?

How would you answer these questions?

Dreams access what waking life cannot:

This dream, and his response to it, opened up concerns and fears this patient “never could or would think, feel, discuss, even imagine” in everyday life.

Sigmund Freud

1856–1939

Dreams as the royal road to the unconscious· Wishes, conflicts, and the work of disguise

Why Dreams Matter — What They Can Illuminate

Psychological & Emotional Symptoms

Dreams can reflect the inner source of anxiety, depression, or repetitive behavioral patterns before the dreamer is consciously aware of the connection.

Hidden Motivations & Conflicts

What we want but cannot admit to wanting. What we fear but cannot acknowledge fearing. Dreams give unspoken experience a voice.

Disavowed Experiences & Emotions

Anger we've repressed. Grief we haven't allowed ourselves to feel. Love we've denied. Dreams often bypass our social inhibitions.

Undeveloped Aspects of the Self

Carl Jung believed dreams show us what we are not yet — capacities, relationships, and aspects of identity that have not yet been integrated into conscious life.

Unremembered or Avoided Experience

Early trauma, childhood loss, formative experiences that were never processed consciously can emerge symbolically in dream imagery.

Creative Potentials

Kekulé discovered the benzene ring from a dream. Paul McCartney heard the melody of Yesterday in a dream. The dreaming mind is not bound by waking logic.

Freud — The Interpretation of Dreams (1900)

Freud's central argument: dreams are not random. They are the disguised fulfillment of a repressed wish — and the disguise tells you as much as the wish does.

The Dream Has Two Layers

The **manifest content** is the dream as you remember it — the story, the images, the sequence.

The **latent content** is the hidden meaning — the unconscious wish or conflict the dream is managing.

The Dream-Work: How the Mind Disguises

Condensation: multiple people/ideas compressed into one image.

Displacement: emotional weight shifted from what matters to something apparently minor.

Symbolization: abstract conflicts represented as concrete images.

Defenses: Reaction formation, denial, dissociation, repression, projection, undoing and more

The Triangle of Conflict

Every dream reflects the same three-part structure:

- A **wish** or desire or impulse
- A **threat** experienced as an **unpleasurable feeling** associated with the wish
- A **defense** that manages the emotional pain

The Day Residue

Dreams almost always incorporate material from the previous day or two — **not because the day's events are what the dream is "about," but because they provide the raw imagery through which the unconscious conflict is expressed.**

Freud — The Sources of Conflict That Dreams Manage

Freud believed that the deepest conflicts reflected in dreams originated in childhood — experiences and fears that the adult mind still carries: Something to be feared in the future generates anxiety — something that's already happened creates depression

Abandonment: The loss of the caretaking other — of being left utterly alone

Rejection/Disdain: Loss of the caretaker's love, affection, or respect

Loss of Power: Fear of being controlled, overwhelmed, or rendered helpless

Guilt: Self-condemnation for wishes or actions that experienced as forbidden

Shame: A pervasive sense that the self itself — not just an action, but the person — is defective or inadequate

A Patient's Dream — “Do You Love Me”

I'm lying on the couch and you come down and lie down next to me. I say “you can't do that because you don't love me.”

You get up and sit in your chair and say “you're right, I don't love you.”

Then I realize that's a good thing — you're not supposed to love me. That's not the reason that I am here.

Freud's questions

What is the wish?

What is the emotional pain?

What is the defense/coping strategy?

— Patient's dream about his therapist

Carl Jung

1875–1961

Dreams as developmental messages · The self speaking to the ego · Individuation

Jung — Dreams as Accurate Pictures of the Psyche

Jung agreed with Freud that dreams are meaningful — but disagreed fundamentally about what they mean and what they are for.

Dreams are not disguises — they are accurate

Where Freud saw dreams as distorted wish-fulfillment, Jung saw them as genuine attempts by the unconscious to communicate what consciousness is missing or avoiding. **The dream does not conceal — it reveals. It is like a letter to oneself that needs to be read.,**

The Compensatory Function

Dreams tend to balance or compensate for the one-sidedness of consciousness. If you are excessively rational in waking life, your dreams may be intensely emotional. If you are anxious, dreams may show unexpected freedom or power.

Everything in the dream is part of you

Every person, animal, and object in your dream represents an aspect of your own psyche. The pursuer, the stranger, the terrifying figure — these are not external threats, but **unknown parts of yourself.**

Individuation — the developmental process

Jung believed psychological development is an instinctual process — like physical growth. **Dreams are communications from that developmental process,** guiding the individual toward greater wholeness. Ignoring them has consequences.

Jung — What Happens When the Dream Is Not Heard

For Jung, dreams are not optional dispatches from the unconscious. They are increasingly insistent communications:

1

Integration:

When dream images and their meanings are accepted and integrated into conscious life, psychological development — individuation — progresses. The person grows.

2

Escalation:

When the messages are ignored, the dreams become more vivid, more disturbing, more insistent. The unconscious turns up the volume.

3

Nightmares:

The dream becomes a nightmare — “a psychic shout,” in Jung’s terms. A last-ditch increase in intensity in order to be heard. The dreamer wakes frightened.

4

Symptoms:

If the developmental signal continues to be ignored, symptoms appear — anxiety, depression, behavioral patterns that make no rational sense. The unconscious has found another way to speak.

A Patient's Dream — “Do You Love Me”

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You get up and sit in your chair and say “you're right, I don't love you.”

Then I realize that's a good thing — you're not supposed to love me. That's not the reason that I am here.

Jung's Questions

What part of the dreamer is the “you” in the dream?

What does it mean if the dreamer doesn't love and isn't supposed to love himself?

What must the dreamer do to “balance this onesided situation?”

Freud vs. Jung — An Essential Disagreement

Two giants, one subject, very different conclusions. The disagreement influenced the history of psychotherapy. It is only recently that it has become possible to see the human experience through multiple lenses.

Question	Freud	Jung
What is the dream doing?	Protecting the dreamer from emotional pain by disguising and unconsciously managing a repressed wish and the threat it entails	Communicating what consciousness is missing
Is the meaning hidden?	Yes — the dream conceals in order to manage emotional pain	No — the dream reveals accurately; we must learn to understand its language
Where does the content come from?	Personal unconscious — repressed childhood conflicts	Both personal and collective unconscious — universal human themes which reflect individual psychological development
How are dreams used?	Uncover and manage the conflict revealed in the latent content behind the disguise	Integrate the dream's message into conscious life
What do recurring nightmares mean?	Failed dreams — defenses overwhelmed by anxiety	Escalating developmental signals — the psyche demanding attention
the dreamer's active participation	The dreamer's associations point toward the latent meaning	The dreamer must enter into an internal dialogue with the dream's imagery

Working With Your Own Dreams

A practical approach · No therapist required · How to begin

How to Work With a Dream — A Practical Protocol

1

Write it down or record it:

Memory of dreams decays within minutes of waking. Keep a notebook or your phone beside the bed. Record in the present tense: “I am walking through a house I don’t recognize.” Not past tense.

2

Give it a title:

Naming a dream gives it a form and helps your memory hold it. “The locked room.” “The pursuit.” “The exam I haven’t studied for.” The title is itself an interpretation.

3

Identify the emotions

What were you feeling in the dream? What are you feeling now, remembering it? The emotion is often the clearest signal available — often more reliable than the narrative logic.

4

Associate freely to significant elements:

Pick 2–3 images, figures, or moments that feel charged. Say whatever comes to mind about each — don’t censor. The dream’s meaning tends to emerge through the associations, not only through analysis of the dream directly.

5

Look for the day residue:

What happened yesterday, or in the past few days, that might connect to any element of the dream? The triggering event is often not what the dream is “about,” but it provides the imagery.

Nightmares and Trauma Dreams

Nightmares are not failures. They are the unconscious speaking at maximum volume.

Freud on Nightmares

Failed Dreams:

The defenses that normally allow a disturbing wish to appear in disguised form have been overwhelmed. The anxiety breaks through.

The Repetitive Nightmare:

Freud initially struggled with nightmares that repeated trauma — they didn't fit his wish-fulfillment theory. He eventually attributed them to a “compulsion to repeat.”

Beyond the Pleasure Principle:

Trauma dreams forced Freud to revise his theory. The mind seemed driven to return to painful experience not because it desired pain, but because it was trying, unsuccessfully, to master it.

Jung on Nightmares

The Psychic Shout:

A nightmare is the unconscious turning up the volume to maximum. Something the ego has been ignoring is now demanding to be addressed.

Developmental Crisis:

Nightmares often appear at moments of major life transition — adolescence, midlife, grief, retirement. The psyche is signaling that change is required.

Trauma Dreams:

When nightmares replay real events verbatim, they exceed both Freud's and Jung's frameworks. Trauma dreams are not disguised or compensatory — they are repeated replays of overwhelming experience.

PTSD Dream — 45-year-old former soldier

I am in the large garage with my platoon. We're there to meet with an informer who will give us information on the enemy's position. I hear the sound of a truck approaching and am terrified.

The door to the garage bursts open and a truck crashes into the open space. I try to run, but before I can move the truck explodes.

I awake sweating, panicked and looking for my gun.

Returning to Where We Started

I leave Frost Amphitheater to go home after a performance. I was with my friend Marty, but I lost him in the crowd. I am alone, walking along a path behind the apartments and shops on El Camino. I think my car is parked in this direction, but I'm not sure.

I walk on and it gets dark. The path is now bordered by 30 foot high cement walls that I think shouldn't be there. I begin to doubt I'll find the car or ever see Marty again.

What do you notice now that you didn't notice at the start of the lecture?

Freud might ask:

What childhood fear does this map onto? Trapped, helpless, nowhere to turn? The walls closing in? Is there a coping strategy (a defense) in the dream? Is this a failed dream, a nightmare?

Jung might ask:

Who is Marty in this dream? What part of you does he represent? What does "going home" mean to you?

We might ask:

What was happening in Dr. Charlton's life the days before this dream? What is the emotional truth of walking alone into the dark?

TONIGHT'S HOMEWORK

Your Dream Diary

- As you put your head on the pillow, tell yourself: “I want to remember a dream tonight.”
 - When you wake up, retell yourself the dream and give it a title.
 - Write down or record it in the present tense.
 - Bring your dream to Lecture 2. If you want email me your dream. I'll try to use some of them on Wednesday.
-

Take Home Points – Dreams

“A dream which is not interpreted is like a letter which is not read,” from the Talmud most closely resembles Carl Jung’s views. His notion of a positive developmental unconscious force which communicates to consciousness through dreams, symbols, myths and repetitive archetypal patterns is much like receiving a letter from your inner self.

2

What are the 3 elements of Freud’s conflict theory which appear in dreams?

1. Wish or desire 2. Threat of emotional pain 3. Coping strategy or defence

3

Define and differentiate shame and guilt. 1. Shame-a pervasive sense that the self itself — not just an action, but the person is ineffective or inadequate. 2. Guilt- a belief one has done something wrong/bad and deserves to be punished (self-condemnation).

4

What are the common elements of typical anxiety dreams? 1. Failing in a dream at a previously successful venture which generates anxiety in the dream actually about a hidden immediate issue

5

Which theory of nightmares makes the most sense to you? Failed dream defences (Freud) or your psyche increasing the volume to get your attention (Jung)? Why that one?